I Don’t Feel Like Dancing

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/39663747.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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I Don’t Feel Like Dancing

by PointlesslyPoetic

Summary

Will one goofy argument about cutlery in the dish washer ruin the Alliance’s night of romance and revelry at the annual Athletic Gala ?

(Probably, yeah.)

Notes

Sorry this took so long this fic rlly didn’t wanna be written. S/o to @deheerkonijn for the many silly convos and immaculate beta reading

See the end of the work for more notes

As far as galas went, this was easily the nicest one Adora had ever been to. Bright Moon City Hall, an ancient and ornate building in the center of the town, was dripping with more tax-payer endorsed wealth than normal. Gold leaf seemed to be the cornerstone of the architecture, and gauzy fabric strips in white, sunset pink, and blushing lilac overlaid the harsher, more modern fixtures to transport the evening's guests back in time to the Renaissance. Or maybe the Victorian Era? Adora didn't know, she hadn't studied either.

There were several axioms about tonight: her mask was itchy as fuck, she wished she'd worn comfier shoes, and this wasn't going to be nearly as fun without Catra. Next to her, Glimmer was chatting her ear off about some old factoid that Bow had told her about City Hall, but Adora had tuned her out about three minutes ago. She loved Glimmer, she really did, but she couldn't care less about Count Von Bunterfuckle who had licked every doorknob in here or whatever. Bow did, and therefore Glimmer did, and that was how couples worked. Or at least, how they usually worked. Everything Adora knew about relationships had been flipped on its end this past week.

One stupid locker room argument, just *one little disagreement* , and now every single friend was on the verge of a breakup.

How the fuck did this even happen?

– MONDAY, 5 DAYS BEFORE GALA –

Catra was late, and Adora was anxious. Catra was often late, usually measured in five minute increments by how badly her coach had pissed her off the day before, but this was different. She and Adora had made plans to get coffee before they hit the weight room that morning; concrete, see-you-there, drop-a-pin-to-my-location plans. She had missed coffee, the cup Adora had gotten her now condensating and separating in the humidity of the stretching area. Everyone else was there. Bow and Glimmer helping each other lean into their stretches, Perfuma, in lotus pose, Scorpia, in shavasana against the wall, Sea Hawk next to her, pretending to do the same while he really grabbed a fast nap, Mermista, not even pretending to stretch and instead scrolling her instagram, and Coach Netossa, on the phone with her wife, whose PT practice was contracted with the Plex.

Everyone but Catra.

Coach Netossa hung up, and turned to them, doing a quiet head count. Her eyes narrowed, and found Adora, who slurped her coffee and decided that counting the dead flies stuck in the overhead light would be a fun little activity. "Grayskull. Where's-"

"I'm here, I'm here!" The double steel doors banged open like they were made of plastic, and in stormed a noticeably pissed off Catra. Grumpy Catra was normal. Pissed Off Catra was a portent. "Sorry, like, for real. My roommate decided that this morning was the best possible time to bitch about how I organize cutlery in the dishwasher, because why not."

Already in her leggings and hand-cut tank top, Catra tossed her gym bag in the direction of the locker room and threw herself onto the mat, folding into a butterfly position. Glimmer raised a

brow at her. “How do you organize cutlery in the dishwasher that makes it so incendiary?”

“Down, of course. So I don’t stab my god damn hands every time I unload the washer.”

Adora frowned. “But…that’s less sanitary.”

“Not enough to count.” Catra’s head popped off the ground to glare at her. “Besides, doesn’t Arrows do the dishes at your place.”

“We have a rotating chore schedule.” Bow chimed in proudly, heedless of the derisive snort Catra tossed him. “And I agree with Catra! It hurts the other way.”

“Yeah, but then you don’t have to do a second cycle for the food bits.” Glimmer rolled her eyes.

“If you rinsed them before you dumped them in, like I told you-” Bow was cut off by Scorpia skootching into the circle.

“What are we talking about? Hey, Wildcat, glad you could make it!”

“Scorpia, I’m here every day.”

“I’m still glad.” Scorpia smiled, and Adora found herself smiling back. The woman possessed a contagious sort of kindness.

“Scorpia, cutlery in the dishwasher- points up or down?”

“Oh, I go points up for maximum sanitation, but Perfuma does points down.”

Perfuma folded herself into the circle next. “Yes, I always end up cutting my hand when the points are up.”

“Heh, I always forget,” Scorpia rubbed her head sheepishly. “It’s not like I can feel it anyway.”

Adora wasn’t, like, as bright as half her friends academically, but living with Bow and Glimmer had given her spades of emotional intelligence and right now, there seemed to be a current of tension between her usually zen friends. Scorpia and Perfuma rarely, if ever, argued, both vocal advocates of communication. But now, they sat on either side of Bow, not quite making eye contact. Adora frowned, but Coach Netossa sat down next to her before she could say anything.

“Alright, let’s widen the circle. Mermista, wake up Sea Hawk and get over here.”

Mermista got to her feet with a groan, and walked over to where their arsonist was now snoring against the floor. She kicked him in the flank none too gently before flopping into their circle. “What are you all on about?”

“Cutlery in the dishwasher- up or down.” Catra was tired of repeating herself.

“Points down, duh.”

“And him?”

Sea Hawk sat next to Scorpia, and Adora frowned more. Now that she looked, none of the couples were sitting together. Only Bow and Glimmer seemed their usual selves. “Up! Cleanliness before godliness, or so they say.”

“That’s not what they say.” Catra frowned.

“Well, it’s what I say.”

“Jesus Christ,” Netossa muttered. “Alright, left over right, cross.” As they stretched, she spoke. “And I’m with Sea Hawk, as much as that gives me agita. Points up, or else I get skeeved out by the idea of it sitting in food water- eugh.” She cut herself off to gag.

“If there’s still food on the forks, just run it again.” Glimmer groaned. Bow frowned.

“That’s a huge waste of water, babe. Just rinse them before and it shouldn’t matter which way you put it.”

Adora frowned. Now there was tension between her roommates, awesome. Catra nodded. “Yep, I’m with Bow.”

Scorpia shrugged. “I don’t see what the big deal is, honestly. Just, be careful when you unload? And put the knives, which always go down, in their little holders. Problem solved.”

Netossa nodded. “It’s the principle, not the practice. Cross over, right to left, lean with it. I don’t care about the injury. I care more about not getting some gross ass disease from leftover soap or old food. If your shit’s pointing down, there’s more germs.”

“I’ve been loading my cutlery in face down for like, a decade, and have never gotten any disease from using it, sooooo…”

“I don’t see why you care, it’s not like you unload it anyway.” Sea Hawk scoffed as he rolled his shoulders.

Mermista glared. “Um, rude?”

Glimmer shrugged. “I’m with Sea Hawk and Scorpia. And so is Adora-”

“Oh, uh, I really don’t-”

But Glimmer steam rolled over her attempt to dislodge herself from the brewing war. “I’d rather cut my hand up a little bit for cleaner forks.”

“If you get blood on them they’re not clean anymore.” Perfuma hummed, smug. Mermista smirked, and offered her a fist bump. “I’ve never had to run a second cycle because my spoons were facing down, and the other way is essentially a guaranteed injury.”

“Alright, let’s give this up for now.” Netossa stopped the argument, bringing them all back to focus. “We’ve got some big meets and matches this week, I need you all in the zone. Not focused on whatever this is. Up you go, time for windsprints.

–THE GALA –

Glimmer loved Adora with all her heart. She had dropped into their lives unexpectedly, a gift from a universe that knew just what they needed, even if at the time they hadn’t seen it that way. She was the best friend Glimmer ever had: considerate, clumsy in her affection, unspeakably kind. She was not, however, a fun party date. Adora oscillated between complete unresponsive

dissociation and vibrating anxiety, and it was absolutely not the vibe Glimmer had wanted for tonight.

The Masquerade Gala was an every-other year type event. Every athlete at the Plex, their sponsors, a plus-one if they so chose, got dressed to the nines and spent the evening dancing, wining, dining, and relaxing in decadence. Some local politicians, like her own mother, the mayor, attended as well, everyone rubbing elbows in view of cameras and reporters. Glimmer was certain they were all going to end up on dress review Tiktok, which was fine. Their little group had gained millions of followers between them, so it was nothing new, per se. She had even done a little 'get ready with me' video earlier in the day. Hopefully no one commented on the lack of Bow.

"Wanna go hit the bar first?" Glimmer nudged Adora.

"Hm? Yeah, sure. Hey, do you think-"

"Adora, are you going to be pining like this all night?"

The blonde's jaw opened comically wide in offense. "Wha- wh- I- you- I am not- how could- why would you-"

"Yeah, okay. I need some wine." Glimmer dragged her friend over to the bar, ordering a glass of Pinot and a vodka seltzer for her calorie-conscious lightweight date. Drinks in hand, they turned toward the large hall full of elegantly laid tables and a large

dancefloor. They found their table, seating with Angella, Micah, Castaspella, and Adam, should he make it back from the coast on time. Adora's twin brother wasn't an athlete like Adora anymore, so she'd given him the plus one so he could come to the Gala and catch up with friends he still had here. He was perpetually late, though, so Glimmer wasn't holding her breath.

They dropped their stuff on the chairs at their indicated place settings, and took fortifying sips of their drinks. "Ready to make the rounds?"

Adora nodded, looking every bit the army general Glimmer was certain she was in a past life. "Let's do this."

Rubbing elbows with people who held your paychecks in their hands was never easy. Glimmer had been taught diplomacy and the art of schmoozing very young, but it still gave her hives. Adora wasn't so lucky, but thankfully most of their sponsors found her blunt social unawareness charming and amusing, so it worked out. She was pretending to laugh over something ridiculously lame and probably offensive when the moment she'd been dreading all night caught her eye.

Bow had arrived, with Perfuma on his arm, and Glimmer found herself instantly seething. They looked fantastic, their identities obvious even with the masks. Bow's was a soft pink fabric overlaid with bold geometric gold pieces, hearts stamped near the eyes. Perfuma's was green with pink flowers, looking almost woven together. Glimmer knew her own was beautiful, and undeniably *her* - soft lavender wings, her favorite color, flaring to her ears, dusted with glitter. Adora's was simple, white satin with gold accents, framing not just her eyes but the tops of her jawbone as

well. Bow waved to them, and Adora moved to wave back, but Glimmer snatched her hand out of the air and forced a laugh.

"Oh my *god* , Adora, that's hilarious! Tell me more."

Adora just blinked, brain struggling to catch up. "More…what?"

" *Anything!* " She hissed, watching it finally click in Adora's brain. She jolted to life like she'd been shocked just as Bow and Perfuma reached them.

"And, uh, yeah, that's why Swift Wind and I aren't allowed in the Starbucks drive through anymore! Crazy, the stuff you get banned for there, huh?"

Perfuma smiled in gentle confusion. "Your stuffed horse isn't allowed in a Starbucks?"

"Oh, no, Swiftwind, one word, is my plushie unicorn. Swift Wind, two capitals, is my, like, actual horse!" Adora whipped her phone out of her clutch and turned her live background on, showing Perfuma the collage of pictures of her and the white gelding she rode. "Isn't he cute?"

Perfuma watched with actual interest. "Oh, he's absolutely darling, Adora! Were the rainbow braids for Pride?"

“Yup! We walked in the local parade in my hometown! That’s where he lives, with my aunt Razz and my cousin Mara. I miss him a lot.” She smiled sadly, stuffing her phone back in her clutch. Glimmer couldn’t even be mad at the breach of Girl Code; Adora was just too cute.

They lingered for a few minutes, Adora and Perfuma carrying the bulk of the chat while Bow and Glimmer focussed on ignoring one another, as elegantly and casually as they could. By the time the other pair walked away to grab drinks and put down their stuff, Glimmer was left feeling victorious. Hollow and sad, sure, but like her mother always said – a win was a win.

–TUESDAY, 4 DAYS BEFORE THE GALA–

“Glimmer, I don’t understand why you’re still so mad about this.”

The door to their apartment didn’t *quite* slam shut, but it was a near thing. Bow followed his steaming, in all ways, girlfriend through the entry hall and into the kitchen, juggling the grocery bags and his phone and the potted plant he’d grabbed on a whim on their way out of the store.

“Be *cause* ,” Glimmer groaned. “It wasn’t the stupid argument itself, it was the *way* you were talking about it- about me!”

Bow stared at the back of her pink head for a long moment. "Could you please elaborate? I don't understand what you mean." He picked his words carefully, making sure to keep his tone even.

"You were- It was so-" Glimmer started snatching produce out of the cloth bags and tossing it harshly in the sink as she grappled for words. Bow mourned the grapes he would lose to her wrath. "It just wasn't super cool how you were talking about me in front of our friends, okay?"

Bow blinked. "Okay, how was I talking about you?"

"You know! Like 'oh, Glimmer puts them in like this' and 'yeah, I can't believe she does it like that either!'." Her voice dropped in a poor interpretation of his own and Bow knew that laughing right now would absolutely land him on the couch, so he reined it in. "It felt like I was the butt of all the 'dude-jokes' and you were laughing at me!"

"I'm sorry, Glimmer," he frowned, grabbing the chicken breast out of the bags once she was done mangling their fruits and veggies. "I didn't mean to make you feel like that. I thought we were all just joking around."

"Well, I wasn't laughing." She sniffed imperiously. Bow scowled.

"You were with Adora, and Netossa. And I *know* I heard you going 'wah, Glimmer and Adora do something different and now my

vibes are off’,” he raised his voice to mimic her mimicking him. “And that felt kind of shitty!”

“That’s not the same thing!”

“How is that not the same thing!”

“Because, ugh!” She threw her hands up, cheeks flushing with either anger or embarrassment. “It just is, okay?”

“No! Not okay! You get to joke about me whenever you think it’s funny but I can’t do the same about you?”

“No, you can’t!” Glimmer shook the draining box of strawberries viciously, not looking at him.

Bow glowered. “This is so stupid! We’re arguing about forks in a dishwasher, and furthermore, *I’m right!* ” He closed the fridge harshly. “And for what it’s worth, your comment about water usage was kind of shitty, Glimmer.”

“Oh, please,” she rolled her eyes. “You know I didn’t mean it like that-”

“Then how did you mean it?” When she didn’t answer, he just shook his head. “You know, you can be so down to earth, sometimes I forget what a *spoiled brat* you really are!”

He stormed out of the kitchen, ignoring her enraged gasp, and the pang of guilt echoing in his chest.

–THE GALA–

When Bow had called asking her to buddy up with him for the formal, Perfuma had leapt at the chance to avoid a night of awkward, sad conversation with her partner. Now, she just felt incredibly guilty. She knew she was bad at conflict, and her avoidant personality could cause her issues, but this was a new level of Bad. She and Scorpia hadn’t spoken in the last forty-eight hours, and Perfuma wasn’t opaque enough to think it was anything but her fault.

“Want me to grab you a drink?” Bow was a sweet guy, and a very kind date. Perfuma smiled.

“Thanks, Bow. I’ll put our stuff down.”

She was lingering by their table, waiting for any familiar and friendly face to come through the doors, when her prayers were very ironically answered. Scorpia, dressed in a deep black cocktail dress with a very generous slit up the right leg and a plunging neckline, stepped through the curtained archway, clearly nervous

behind her geometric ruby mask. She looked seconds away from wringing her deep red hands together, and Perfuma wanted more than anything to go to her-

Scorpia relaxed when a hand thumped her shoulder, and she turned to laugh at something Sea Hawk was saying to her. Perfuma could feel her emotions souring, and turned away from the laughing pair to go find her date.

How had she let this spiral into such a mess?

–WEDNESDAY, 3 DAYS BEFORE THE GALA–

Logically, Scorpia knew that other things were clearly amiss for Perfuma to be this out of sorts. That the entire night going pear-shaped wasn't *her* fault, or, at the very least, her fault alone. But, it was a little hard to remember that as they went on to their twentieth minute of cold-shoulder silence. And Perfuma's apartment, though airy and light and filled with more plants than anyone could possibly hope to have cohabitating in one space, was far too small for the vast chasm that seemed to be gaping wider by the second.

"Um," Scorpia hated the way her voice shook, hated the way the Fear and Anxiety came to gnaw at her even though this was *Perfuma* , her partner, who loved her more than life. She had nothing to be afraid of here. And yet. "D-do you want me to do the, uh, the dishes? While you meditate?"

Perfuma exhaled more sharply than normal through her nose. "Yes, Scorpia. That would be very helpful, thank you." And although there was nothing particularly pointed or passive aggressive about the way she said it- in fact, she answered her very calmly- each word felt like it was being shouted at her by a hissing, spitting monster.

"O-okay."

Scorpia retreated to the kitchen, thankful she'd worn her waterproof prosthetics. The rote motion of rinsing the dishes, and then playing tetris with the admittedly puny washing unit, was soothing, and she let her mind wander over the past week.

She and Perfuma had been having some sort of weird disconnect for about five, maybe six days now. As her other half would say, the "vibes" were just "off". And while Scorpia didn't really know exactly what that meant, like, literally, she could agree with the general feeling. They were out of balance, out of harmony. Scorpia had brought over Thai one night, totally forgetting that Perfuma was cooking. Then Perfuma had interrupted one of her solo training sessions with Huntara, something the elder boxer did not take kindly to. They'd gotten each other's coffee orders wrong all week, gone out when they had said they were going to stay in and forgotten. Scorpia had been 7 holes deep in a game of golf on Monday with Adora, Sea Hawk, and Netossa when Perfuma had asked her if she remembered to pick up her custom tea order from the boutique by Scorpia's apartment. *That* had been an uncomfy phone call. And then Perfuma had nearly washed one of the microchips for her left arm when she didn't check the pockets before throwing on laundry.

Needless to say, her nerves were totally shot. And right now, being in this apartment was starting to feel like a situation she needed to escape from; her skin was tight, her heartbeat was uncomfortably loud, and *wow* was she sweating-

"Scorpia!"

Perfuma's dismayed cry tore her from her reverie, and she felt herself subconsciously tensing, locking up her muscles. "Uh, yes? What's up?"

Her girlfriend sighed, as if very put upon, and bent over the dishwasher. "I've asked you, like, one hundred times, to please put the prongs down when you load the forks and knives into the dishwasher!"

"Oh, jeez! I'm sorry, 'Fuma." Scorpia scratched the back of her head. "I just-"

"Forgot?" Perfuma planted her hands on her hips. "I know. You've been forgetting a lot lately. I just…don't understand why you can't remember!" She threw her hands up, and Scorpia knew she was nearing the end of a well-frayed rope. She opened her mouth to say…something helpful, maybe, but Perfuma wasn't listening. "I tell you every time it's your turn to wash, and every time, it doesn't happen! I don't know how to get through to you, and I don't get why you don't get it! The points go down, because otherwise, it stabs your hands and cuts them up and it *hurts*- "

"No, it doesn't."

Perfuma turned around, indignant, until horror and understanding crept over her face in equal measure. "Scorpia…Scorpia, I'm sorry, I didn't mean-"

"S'okay," she scratched the back of her head. "Guess we're both forgetting a lot lately, huh?"

"Scorpia," Perfuma looked ready to cry- no, scratch that, she was crying. "I'm sorry, please-"

"I'm, uh, I'm gonna head out, I think." She kept her eyes on her sneakers. They were really scuffed up, she should look for a new pair this weekend. "Long day tomorrow, you know how it is." She turned, grabbing her worn leather jacket off the chair by the island. She could hear Perfuma sniffle, and shuffle, like she wasn't sure if she could go to her. Scorpia kept her eyes on the door, and, hey, wow, when did they get so blurry and wet? "Um. Okay. I'll…see you tomorrow. Maybe. Bye."

As she took off down the stairs, she did have the distinct feeling of fleeing a war zone, escaping some powerful enemy by the skin of her teeth. The relief that hit her when she pushed out onto the busy sidewalk just made the tears fall faster.

– THE GALA –

Sea Hawk understood why Scorpia had wanted to avoid the Gala altogether. Fighting with your dearest love never put anyone in the mood for an evening of dancing, no matter how whimsical and well-decorated the event may be. And the room was, admittedly, like something out of a dream.

He tore his eyes away from the sparkling ceiling when Scorpia jostled his shoulder. He squinted at her lips while he fiddled with his aid. “What was that?”

“Want a drink?”

“Oh! Certainly!” He beamed. “Here, I’ll toss our stuff on the table.”

“Ooh, I hope we’re sitting with fun people!”

Sea Hawk trotted over to the table and scanned the name cards. Entrapta, Hordak, Lonnie, Rogelio, and Kyle. Sea Hawk knew of Hordak and Kyle, but had never met them. Lonnie, Rogelio, and Entrapta, however, were never a bad time. Entrapta could slam down drinks like a professional, and Lonnie’s running commentary of the snobby sponsors would keep the energy up. And keep him distracted.

It was odd, walking into a function without Mermista by his side. They’d met at a party, some coed mingling thing that was

supposed to get the athletes to make friends at the Plex. It had worked out for him, at least. She'd accosted him when he went to get a refill, leaned against a wall off to the side of the room, not quite hiding, more just…observing. "Hey," she'd said. "If you had to stage a heist of this building, how would you do it?"

"Easy," he'd replied, popping a shrimp in his mouth. "In through the laundry door, climb up the chute, get into the air ducts, and wing it from there."

"That's…really bad. You'd get caught so fast."

"Impossible."

"Why?"

"I don't even know what a heist is."

She'd stared at him in confusion, and alarm, like all of his teachers ever. But then, she'd laughed, just a little chuckle but still a laugh- and they'd been planning party-heists together ever since.

Now, he was alone, feeling exposed without her around, and he only had himself to blame. But what else was new there?

– THURSDAY, 2 DAYS BEFORE THE GALA –

"Look, if you're going to keep doing this on purpose just to piss me off, feel free to get the fuck out anytime, dude."

Sea Hawk was clearly smothering a chuckle, which was only spiking Mermista's blood pressure higher. She wasn't really prone to blowing up, preferring a walled-off freeze-out approach to most conflicts, but she had had the week from hell and was about ready to burst.

On Sunday, she wiped out hard, and dashed her surfboard against some rocks she hadn't seen; the massive crack she found down its middle was an epitaph. To make things worse, the custom shop she ordered her boards from was closed for the whole month. Some 'family emergency' or what the fuck ever. Then Monday, the vibes from the whole group were rancid as hell thanks to the stupid dishwasher argument. Which was now coming back to bite her ass, so that totally *rocked* . Tuesday and Wednesday her times were off, her coach was riding her like a goddamn bicycle to do better, and when she'd got home, she realized she'd left her leftovers out the night before so now her whole kitchen smelled like lackluster tacos *and* she had no dinner. And today, after a long day of morning practice and then fucking *dress shopping* - finding anything remotely desi in this white-ass town? She might as well be looking for El Dorado- she'd come home to find Sea Hawk outside her door, waiting for her.

Foolishly, she'd let him into her residence, where he'd offered to do the dishes. Except he did them wrong on purpose to rile her up, and tonight was a night that she really didn't need to be riled any further.

“Alright, alright, my bad,” he responded in a tone that implied he really didn’t care who’s bad it was. “I’m sorry.”

“Doubtful.” She rolled her eyes and huffed, turning away to finish tossing the groceries she’d grabbed in the fridge. Sea Hawk made a wounded noise, but she ignored him. “Don’t you have an apartment you live in? That isn’t, like, here?”

“I got lonely. And bored.” He hoisted himself onto the counter, making no move to rearrange the dishwasher. She clenched her jaw.

“Where’s Scorpia?”

“At Perfuma’s,” he tossed a mango between his hands, eyes wandering around her kitchen. “Is that a new tapestry?” He gestured to the woven runner she’d folded up and left on the counter; it had only arrived yesterday and she wasn’t sure where she wanted it yet.

“Yep.”

“From the market?”

“No, my mom sent it over.”

“That’s nice,” he smiled. “They’re still coming to visit next weekend right?”

Mermista’s jaw tightened. Her superbly shitty week had been a great distraction from the, like, actual issue she was having. “Nope.” She decided rearranging her cheese drawer would be the next best thing for her to do tonight.

“Aw, that sucks,” Sea Hawk pouted. “But, hey, now you can make it to the beach with all of us.”

“Yeah, I guess.” She mumbled.

“Do you…not wanna go?”

“I don’t know, dude!” She groaned. “I was just really, like, fixated on this visit. So the idea of what I’m gonna do instead hasn't occurred to me yet, okay?”

“I mean…I guess.” He grumbled. “Just thought you’d be excited to spend more time with all of us.”

Mermista’s eyes narrowed, and she shut the drawer, and fridge, with a snap. She whirled on Sea Hawk, not looking even slightly apologetic. “Oh, I’m sooo sorry that I’m not leaping for joy and

scrambling to make plans because my parents suddenly can't see me for the first time in months."

He blinked. "It's not really anything to be sorry over…but, uh, thanks?"

"Are you serious?" She stared at him. "Are you one hundred percent serious?"

"I don't really know what's happening!" He hopped off the counter, hands held up as if to ward her off. She advanced on him anyway.

"Let's recap, okay? You invited yourself over, you did *my* dishes wrong, on purpose, just to fuck with me, you are *happy* that I don't get to see my fucking family, several oceans away usually, because now I get to spend more time with the people I have to see every single day?"

Sea Hawk was frozen, mouth agape. "I- I didn't think-"

"No, Hawk, you didn't think," she had pushed him into the hall now, and yanked his jacket off the hook. "You never think if it isn't convenient to you. Didn't think about how I've had a shit week, that I just got shit news, that I'm tired, and stressed, and maybe, just maybe, didn't want to play your childish games tonight." She threw his coat at him as hard as she could, and watched him

fumble to catch it. “You know, sometimes, you’re the biggest jackass I have ever fucking known. Get out.”

“Mermista-”

“I said *get out!* ” She screamed. Man, it felt good to scream. Seeing the naked fear in Sea Hawk’s face felt less good, especially when he clapped a hand over his bad ear, but she wasn’t in the headspace to reflect on that right now. He turned and fled the apartment, not even bothering to close the door behind him. She stormed up to it, and viciously kicked it shut.

It didn’t make her feel any better.

– GALA –

Catra had been looking forward to this night. Key words: had been. Back when she had found the perfect suit for the occasion, embroidered and tapered and a little retro, knowing that someone there would appreciate it other than her. Back when she and Adora had plans to go together, and then hit up the 24 hour diner after. So, like, two weeks ago.

Now, she’d rather be munching on grip chalk and watching Love It or List It reruns than here in her pinchy shoes. At least her date was just as miserable.

When Mermista had cornered her in the locker room yesterday, eyes rimmed red and anxious, Catra had been furious enough to say yes wholeheartedly. And if she was still that angry, this might have been fun. But now she just felt…stupid. And bad. This whole *thing* she and Adora had been sniping about was ridiculous, even she could admit. The fact that it had cost her a fun and expensive evening was just the cherry on top.

When Mermista had picked her up, her first words of greeting had been, "let's get this over with." Standing here with her, and not Adora, she couldn't help but agree. Don't get her wrong, Mermista was chill. Out of their entire little team of dumbasses, she gelled with her more than most. But…she wasn't tall, shredded, blonde… or wearing the most gorgeous dress.

Catra's jaw felt a little loose as she caught sight of Adora across the floor in a long white gown embellished in gold. Her mask was the same, delicate and airy with metallic accents. Catra's own was a deep plum with dark red scratches in it, like claw marks. They had planned a doing a sort of an opposites theme, light and dark, airy and strong, yadda yadda. It still looked fine but… it could have been better.

Next to her, Mermista was sighing heavily under her own mask. It was detailed to look like scales, teal with gold accents to match the saree she wore. "This sucks."

"Preaching to the choir."

They made their way to the table- seated with Bow, Perfuma, and some other people they didn't know- and then the bar. An old fashioned for her, a sex in the driveway for Mermista ("don't look at me like that. It, like, matches my dress."), and they were lazily making the rounds, greeting sponsors and rubbing elbows and just generally having an ass-blasted time.

Catra's cheeks were starting to hurt from smiling when the host- Angella, Glimmer's mom- announced that it was time for the dance floor to open, and would the athlete's and their dates please join them to kick off the festivities. Personally, Catra would rather gnaw on a piece of rusted rebar until her molars bled, but that was just her.

"C'mon," Mermista slammed down the last of her drink and held out her hand. "Let's get this over with."

"Is this our motto tonight?" She scowled, but took the desi woman's hand and let herself be led onto the floor. Performing gravity defying, physically impossible stunts in front of thousands? Millions if you counted television? Easy. Dancing in front of a live crowd? Catra's own personal hell. "Don't drop me."

"Then loosen up," Mermista hissed as she placed a hand on Catra's waist. "You're stiff as a board."

She did her best to force her muscles to relax, but as soon as the band started playing, they were locking back up again. Mermista rolled her eyes and started leading. Catra bit down on her jealousy as they spun past Glimmer and Adora, both laughing as

they twirled. Scorpia was leading Sea Hawk like they were moving through a house on fire, both laughing raucously. Bow and Perfuma were fluid together, if not slightly reserved. Catra was glad that at least some people were as miserable as she was, and then had what could only be called an out of body moment.

Had they really let a stupid argument about *forks* in the *dishwasher* drive them all to the point of near-breakup?

Yes. Yes they had.

– FRIDAY MORNING, 1 DAY BEFORE GALA –

"Look, all I'm saying is," Catra sipped her oatmilk latte. "I get why they're so ruffled about it. It's a super common domestic dispute!"

"Yeah, I guess," Adora stirred her overnight oats disconsolately. "But they haven't spoken in like. Two days! And I think they're finding different dates for the dance, now."

"Woah… really? I didn't know Arrows was that miffed about it."

"I think he was angrier about the water thing. And, to be fair," Adora looked around nervously, like she was afraid of being overheard before she leaned in to whisper. "Glimmer was kinda being really unfair about it. She just wouldn't budge! And they're the ones always saying compromise is important."

Catra just snorted. “Well. Leave it to them, for now. Who are they going with?”

“Bow’s going with Perfuma and I agreed to go with Glimmer.” Adora averted her eyes, trying to play it as casually as possible. Maybe she wouldn’t…

“Uh, earth to Adora!” Catra snapped. “We agreed to go together?”

“Well…” Adora fiddled with the lid of her mason jar. “We kinda… didn’t. No one ever asked, and there’s no corsage or anything…”

Catra’s jaw was falling open. “You can’t be serious. We said a few months ago-!”

“Exactly,” Adora rolled her eyes. “We said, and we discussed, and we joked. But we didn’t…ask.”

“Are you…mad about that?” Catra blinked slowly. “Look, I just… didn’t think I had to, okay? We’ve done all this stuff together since I came over and I just assumed-”

“You always assume.” Adora muttered, shoving another spoonful in her mouth.

“Okay, what is this really about?” Catra frowned.

Adora fiddled with her lid some more. “On Monday, when we were all talking-”

“Oh my *god* , this cannot be about the fucking dishwasher thing-”

“Yeah, well, it is,” Adora stabbed her oats. “And if you’d let me finish, I could tell you why.” Catra scowled but gestured her on. “Catra, when we disagree, no matter how small…you always call me names. And say really mean things. You call me stupid, and dumbass, and dummy, and I get that that’s how you joke around and that you call it your ‘terms of endearment’ but it- I- I don’t like it. It makes me feel crummy. And then you always do it around the others, and I know I’m not the smartest, but…it kind of hurts.”

Catra was staring at her long and hard, seeming to waver on some edge. “Seriously? That’s what it’s about? God, Adora why didn’t you just say something instead of ditching me like this? You’re such an idiot-”

Adora was up and out of her seat before Catra could even blink, grabbing her gym bag and water bottle. “See, this is exactly what I mean.”

Catra stood, too, reaching out. “Wait, Adora, I didn’t mean-”

“See you at the dance.”

Adora power-walked away, bursting through the doors of the Plex, shoving her way past coaches and fellow athletes and Entrapta with her giant cart of god-knows-what. She threw herself onto a bench in the locker room, ignoring how her hands shook with anger and hurt as she fiddled with her sneakers. It was only when she realized she left her breakfast with Catra that the tears started falling.

– GALA –

Adora was having a great time cruising around the dance floor with Glimmer until she wasn’t. Like dominoes falling, she watched as people began swapping partners, and she turned to hiss. “Is this a king’s dance?”

“Did you not read the itinerary?” Glimmer hissed back.

“ *What itinerary!* ” But then they were separated, and she had landed in the arms of the last person she really wanted to talk to tonight.

“Hey, Adora.”

“Catra.”

“Having fun?” Catra was looking anywhere but at her, and Adora felt the anger from yesterday coming back.

“I was.” She let her eyes trace Catra’s delicate mask, hiding some but not all of her freckles. There were butterflies in her stomach, her veins, that only grew more distressed as her multicolored gaze came back to rest on her face. Instead of the expected annoyance and offense, Catra just looked…sad.

“I, uh…” She stumbled the next step of the dance, and swore quietly in Russian. “Look, I’m bad at…this. But I’m going to try, because this is important, or whatever. I’m sorry I always call you names, or stupid. I’m really bad at being nice, and we can get all therapist-couch about that another time, but. Yeah.” Adora barely remembered to dip her in time, shocked as she was. “I’m not saying it’s an excuse. But it’s my reason. And I’ll try to do better. Because you’re my…friend. And I like you.”

Adora smiled, wobbly. “Even when I’m a dummy?”

“Especially when you’re a dummy.” Seemingly throwing caution (and the dance) to the wind for a moment, she leaned up to press a chaste kiss to Adora’s cheek, just under her mask. Adora was sure her face was on fire.

But Catra's was, too, so it was okay.

"Now, c'mon. Let's make the most of this dumb dance?"

"Only if we can still get milkshakes after."

"Yeah," Catra smiled, open and happy. "That sounds perfect."

– GALA –

Glimmer sighed as she lost Adora to Catra, and nearly tripped into her next partner.

"Woah, hey, you okay?"

She spun around to see Bow, hands up as if ready to catch her, eyes wide with concern. Glimmer flushed in embarrassment. "Uh, yeah, all good. Thanks."

They stood awkwardly for a moment, interrupting the flow of the dance and earning *many* glares, before Bow held out a hand. "May I?"

“Sure.” Glimmer shrugged, avoiding eye contact.

The silence between them, despite the music and laughter all around them, was loud and awkward. A million thoughts, panicked and anxious, were running through Glimmer’s head just like they had since the fight. *He hates me, I’m a bitch, he’s going to leave me, how can I even apologize for being so fucking insensitive, what am I going to do about the apartment, who’s gonna take Adora in the divorce-*

“Hey,” Bow silenced them all like he always did, lifting her gaze to his with a gentle finger under her chin. “You know I love you, right?”

Glimmer’s eyes started to water against her will. His mask, red and white and gold, dotted with hearts, sparkled like his eyes were, and she reached up to trace is carefully. They’d bought them together, and then gone out to her favorite cafe, and it had been the best date of the whole month. She sniffled, and fell into his chest, glitter and feathers be damned. “I’m sorry,” she whispered. “I was such an ass.”

“It’s okay,” Bow hugged her back. “Everyone’s allowed to be an ass sometimes. It’s only human.”

“Are we okay?”

“Yeah,” he chuckled. “I think we’re all ready for this stupid argument to be over.”

“You’re not gonna dump me?”

“...over a fork in the dishwasher?” He sounded like he was barely suppressing some very obnoxious laughter. “Nah, I don’t think so.”

“‘Kay,” Glimmer sniffled. “I love you so much, Bow.”

“I love you, too, Glim.”

– GALA –

Perfuma had already written up her entire apology in her mind, scrapped that, rewritten it, scrapped *that* , and then decided to just wing it the next time she saw Scorpia. Her heart would tell her what to say in the moment, she knew. She just hadn’t expected that moment to be the middle of a crowded dancefloor, but universe could be funny like that.

“Scorpia!” She smiled as the taller woman caught her around the waist mid-switch. Her prosthetics flexed against her hips, and she looked torn between joy and apprehension.

“P-Perfuma! Hey, wow, gosh, uh- fancy meeting you here, huh? Well, I mean, that’s kind of a joke, because, y’know, *obviously*- ”

“It is,” Perfuma gently cut off her rambling. “Fancy, I mean. To see you here.” They swayed through the next few steps, and a dip, before the silence began to grow tense. Perfuma was gnawing on the inside of her lip, trying to figure out what to say.

Scorpia beat her to it. “I’m sorry about the other night, for doing the dishes wrong again and then just leaving-”

“ *No* .” Perfuma had found her voice. “Scorpia, you have absolutely nothing, and I mean *nothing* , to be sorry about. I was the one who blew up at you over something so stupid, and small, and…” She swallowed thickly, willing away tears. Her mascara wasn’t waterproof, but it was cruelty-free and vegan. “And I insulted you in one of the worst ways possible, and I’m so, so sorry.”

Scorpia looked stunned. Perfuma knew she could probably count on two hands the number of times Scorpia had actually received an apology in her life, so she let her process it. “It’s…it’s okay.”

“Please don’t just say it.” She murmured tiredly.

“I’m not…I think. I really am okay with your apology.” Scorpia’s mask, styled after both her name and what they called her in the ring, *The Scorpion* , glittered in the soft light, making her onyx

eyes shine. Perfuma's breath hitched in her chest. "I wasn't okay with what you said. And it does still hurt. But I know you didn't mean it like that. I know you weren't trying to use my situation against me to make me feel bad about myself on purpose. And that's different than how it usually is when people bring it up. So, uh, yeah- it's okay. Or it will be. Because we're gonna work on it." Scorpia smiled, proud of herself. "Right?"

"Absolutely." Perfuma wound her arms around Scorpia's broad shoulders, smiling when she hugged her back. "I really am sorry."

"I know you are," Scorpia murmured in her ear. "Love you, Saguaro."

Perfuma snorted delicately. "I love you, too."

– GALA –

"I'm sorry!" Sea Hawk was blurting out before Mermista's hand had even landed his. She blinked in surprise, both at him being her new partner and his very loud apology, before she forced her face into annoyed neutrality. His throat worked as he swallowed anxiously. "I-I just…wanted you to know."

"Cool." She drawled, eyes briefly scanning his mostly hidden face. His mask was deep navy, embellished with some red beading and gold thread, minimal glitter. It matched his suit perfectly, but she didn't let herself admire how nicely it fit him, or how soft the

fabric was under her hand. She was, like, supremely pissed at him still.

"You don't have to say anything," he was still speaking a little too loudly. "But can I apologize?"

She blinked. "You…just did."

"No- well, yes- but, more."

"Whatever." She rolled her eyes, and they spun in a half circle.

"I was deeply insensitive to your frustration and ire the other night," he began. She rolled her eyes at his prose, but didn't interrupt. "It was uncouth of me, and unfair to you. I knew how important it was for you to see your family next weekend, and how excited you were, and yet I trampled right over those feelings in the moment-"

"Yes, thank you, I remember very clearly what happened." She snapped. "If there's a point to this-"

"My point is," he dipped her gently. "I was a cad. A blundering, rude cad. And a total dickhead." She almost- *almost* - laughed at that. "I'm sorry."

"Just, like, why?" She sighed, finally letting go of some of the anger. "You did the dishes wrong on purpose just to piss me off, and then you just shit all over my feelings. The fuck? It's the toddler shit you do, like that, that makes me want to…"

He stared at her morosely. "Kick me out?"

"Yeah." She shrugged.

He sighed. " I'm sorry. I'm trying to get better at not being 'so much' but it's hard. The other night, I was just annoyed I hadn't seen you in a few days, and then I was so happy at the idea of you coming to the beach with us, I didn't stop to think."

"Shocker."

He smiled a bit, shrugging helplessly. "I can't say I'm going to get better at everything right away. But I can say I'm really, truly sorry for how badly I hurt you. And that I'll never purposely fuck up the dishes again. And that I can try."

She mulled that over as they danced in silence for a few more minutes. Around the floor, their weird upside-down night seemed to be righting itself before her eyes. Adora and Catra were escaping the floor, hand in hand and laughing as they ran off. Glimmer and Bow were swaying gently, both smiling as they held each other tenderly. Scorpia and Perfuma had sat down at a table,

and seemed deep in intense conversation, their foreheads pressed together.

Mermista turned back to Sea Hawk, taking in his anxiety, the naked vulnerability in his eyes, how gently he held her as they moved. She smiled softly. “So, tell me how you’d plan a heist of this building?”

End Notes

Hope you enjoyed! Drop a comment if you did! Or if you didn't! I'm not picky

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!